

a different path for her son. Varun is the first with the Gandhi lineage to have spoken proudly about being a Hindu and a nationalist, a contrast to Rahul who always talks about secularism. It is obvious that Varun realised that in the absence of a strong BJP leadership and a credible slogan, it would be difficult to mobilise even the committed voters of Pilibhit. He found that the language of the Sangh Parivar suited his requirements more and suddenly, he became the voice of the kar sevaks and the likes. He is said to have told friends that his statements were made not in aggression, but were more defensive in nature, since in large parts of the country the ma-

jority community was living in fear. While he can be arrested and prosecuted for his 'uncivilised' rant, there is no way he can be barred from contesting an election. Varun was also fully aware of infirmities in the legal provisions. He has, in recent days, quoted a judgement of the Supreme Court to his

friends where the learned judges said that "statements made during an election campaign, even if inflammatory in nature, should not be taken literally but merely figuratively". The EC, toothless in the matter, asked the BJP to deny him a ticket saying, "Any sponsorship of his candidature would be perceived as endorsing his unpardonable acts". But experts doubt if the EC's missive would stand scrutiny of the law.

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Though the BJP has distanced itself from his statements, the party has made some calculations of political gains to be made in Uttar Pradesh.

The Data Man

Sudhanshu Mittal's biggest asset is that he is a walking talking poll data base

Both Coca-Cola and Pramod Mahajan do not reveal their winning formula," the late BJP leader once said when asked about his electoral strategies. Sudhanshu Mittal, however, was both Mahajan's worst-kept secret and his winning formula. If Mahajan had the flamboyance, Mittal had the flair. Mittal's love for data and details became the backbone of Mahajan's politics. The two were a formidable team ever since they first crunched numbers and networked across parties to install the first BJP-Shiv Sena government in Maharashtra in 1995 without a clear majority.

Since then the duo planned the party strategy for three general elections. Few know that Mittal was the brain behind the 2003 BJP sweep in Rajasthan, a state given to Mahajan to deliver. Eighteen months before the elections, Mittal compiled a comprehensive survey of each constituency in the state, so when the polls were announced the duo were ready with their strategy and a can-



didate list that included 56 'dummy' candidates to split the Congress vote. Today three years after Mahajan's death, Mittal is perhaps the sole inheritor of his legacy and acumen. Before his death, Mahajan had been

handling the 2006 Assembly polls in Assam. Although the BJP lost, Mittal realised that the defeat could have been avoided if the AGP and the BJP had not cut into each other's votes. He took a constituency-wise analysis